

Command words

What each one asks for, how the marks are given, and what the examiners say goes wrong

Write in full sentences, make every point complete, and answer the question that was asked about the scenario that was given.

WHICH WORDS CARRY THE MARKS

Every Paper 1 and Paper 3 question part from 2022 to March 2026: 925 parts in 56 papers. Each part counts under the command word it uses.

Word	Cambridge's definition (syllabus p. 66)	Parts	Share of marks	
Describe	state the points of a topic/give characteristics and main features	451	41.0%	
Explain	set out purposes or reasons/make the relationships between things clear/say why and/or how and support with relevant evidence	197	18.6%	
Discuss	write about issue(s) or topic(s) in depth in a structured way	80	15.4%	
Evaluate	judge or calculate the quality, importance, amount, or value of something	25	4.8%	
Analyse	examine in detail to show meaning, identify elements and the relationship between them	19	3.4%	
Justify	support a case with evidence/argument	20	3.1%	
Complete	not in the syllabus list; an instruction, not a command word	17	3.0%	
Identify	name/select/recognise	28	2.6%	
Compare	identify/comment on similarities and/or differences	16	2.3%	
Draw	not in the syllabus list; an instruction, not a command word	9	1.2%	
Write	not in the syllabus list; an instruction, not a command word	9	1.0%	
Give	not in the syllabus list; an instruction, not a command word	15	1.0%	
State	express in clear terms	13	0.8%	
Contrast	identify/comment on differences	9	0.7%	

“WRITE EVERYTHING IN BULLET POINTS” IS WRONG

1. No Cambridge document for 9626 tells you to answer in bullet points. Cambridge's own guide for students says the opposite.

“Answer the questions in sentences. Never give ‘one word’ or one ‘phrase’ answers.” Cambridge Learner Guide for 9626, p. 15

2. The examiners repeat this in almost every series. Describe and Explain answers need full sentences too, not only the long questions.

"Candidates should also be encouraged to write full sentences and discouraged from writing bulleted, short statements in their responses. Descriptions or explanations can only be conveyed in full sentences." Examiner report, November 2025, Paper 9626/32, p. 16

"Candidates should write full sentences and avoid bulleted short statements in their responses." Examiner report, June 2022, Paper 9626/31, p. 13

3. The real problem with bullets is what they leave out. A bullet is usually a bare point with no reason or detail, and the reason or detail is where most marks are.

"the use of bullet points rarely produces little more than simple points or short statements with no explanations or descriptions" Examiner report, June 2018, Paper 9626/32, p. 17

"Short statements or bulleted responses that do not expand on facts cannot be awarded the higher marks because these are not discussions." Examiner report, November 2022, Paper 9626/31, p. 14

4. For Discuss, Evaluate and Analyse, the shape of the answer matters as well. Lists and tables of statements, even two neat lists of benefits and drawbacks, lose most of the marks.

"learners who produced bulleted lists or tables of statements were unable to access most of the marks" Examiner report, March 2025, Paper 9626/32, p. 10

"if these answers are shown in a sketched table, they do not properly answer the question as there is no e.g., discussion" Examiner report, March 2025, Paper 9626/32, p. 8

"This comment also applies to answers that have separate lists of benefits and drawbacks, but the lists consist of single word or very brief sentences." Examiner report, June 2025, Paper 9626/32, p. 22

How the marks are given

1. You do not lose marks for grammar or spelling. Examiners give marks for correct points and never take marks away for mistakes. Your meaning still has to be clear.

"marks are not deducted for errors" Mark scheme 9626/12, June 2025, p. 2

"answers should only be judged on the quality of spelling, punctuation and grammar when these features are specifically assessed by the question as indicated by the mark scheme. The meaning, however, should be unambiguous." Mark scheme 9626/12, June 2025, p. 2

2. Short sentences are fine. One clear point per sentence is easier for the examiner to mark and easier for you to check.

"Keep most sentences short and focused. That will help with clarity and in making every point stand out for the examiner." Cambridge Learner Guide for 9626, p. 15

3. Many mark schemes give one mark for a point and a second mark only when you add its reason or detail. If you only list bare points, the marks are capped.

"MAX two marks if answers are all only first marks." Mark scheme 9626/13, November 2023, p. 4

4. Answer the question as it is written, about the scenario it gives. Writing everything you know about a word you spotted in the question does not earn the marks.

"the full range of marks is only available to candidates for answers referring to the scenario in the questions" Examiner report, November 2025, Paper 9626/32, p. 16

"Centres must ensure that candidates target their answers to the questions as they are written and not at 'key' words in the questions." Examiner report, June 2024, Paper 9626/31, p. 17

5. Do not copy mark scheme bullets you have memorised. Examiners notice, and a list of learnt points is not an answer to a new question.

"Examiners saw many scripts where candidates listed sets of bullet points that appeared to have been learnt directly from previous mark schemes." Examiner report, November 2019, Paper 9626/11, p. 1

6. The number of marks tells you how many separate points (or point-plus-reason pairs) to make.

"Look at how many marks are allocated to a question. This gives you a clue as to how much work is expected." Cambridge Learner Guide for 9626, p. 15

7. Never leave a question blank. A few sentences on a topic you are unsure of can still earn marks.

"Writing a few sentences, even if little is known about the topic, may gain valuable marks towards the overall total." Examiner report, November 2025, Paper 9626/32, p. 16

Explain

Explain — Cambridge's definition: "Explain set out purposes or reasons/make the relationships between things clear/say why and/or how and support with relevant evidence" Syllabus 2025–2027, p. 66

Make a point, then add a reason for it with 'because', 'so' or 'which means', and repeat until you have covered the marks.

HOW THE MARKS ARE GIVEN

1. Many Explain mark schemes mark a point '(1st)' and the expansion under it '(1)'. The (1st) mark is for your statement. The (1) mark is only for the reason or detail you add to that statement. I counted this in cw_parts.json: 38 of the 176 Explain parts from 2022 to 2025 use (1st) in the mark scheme.

"The sampling rate can affect the quality of audio files/how the audio sounds (1st) – because it captures sounds at discrete points (and not the whole sound) (1)" Mark scheme 9626/12, March 2024, Q10(b), p. 9

"To define/specify the timing of the movement (1st)" Mark scheme 9626/32, November 2023, Q2(a), p. 4

"Access control can be based on attribute of user within company (1st) – so that they can only access data appropriate for their job/task/role (1)" Mark scheme 9626/32, March 2024, Q7, p. 7

2. A point with no reason can still get its one mark, but no more. If every point you write is only a statement, the mark scheme can cap you below full marks.

"A less detailed answer, such as 'they can learn at their own pace' can be given credit as it is a correct statement of the effect, but it lacks the detail to gain any further credit because it does not add an expansion" Examiner report, June 2024, Paper 9626/32, p. 23

"MAX two marks if answers are all only first marks." Mark scheme 9626/13, November 2023, Q3(c), p. 4

3. The expansion mark depends on the first mark. If you do not make the first point, the examiner cannot give the reason mark that goes with it. In a short question, one full point and its reason can be the whole answer.

"A relatively easy first mark was given for any answer that stated that the data is scrambled. Many candidates achieved this mark. Two further marks were then dependant on this answer." Examiner report, June 2024, Paper 9626/11, p. 4

"Max two for one complete explanation" Mark scheme 9626/12, March 2024, Q10(b), p. 9

HOW TO WRITE IT

1. Write explanations in full sentences, not bullet points of a few words. A sentence lets you put the point and its reason together.

"Candidates should be encouraged to write full sentences and discouraged from writing bulleted, short statements in their responses. Descriptions or explanations can only be conveyed in full sentences." Examiner report, November 2022, Paper 9626/31, p. 12

WHAT GOES WRONG

1. Do not just describe what something is. Explain asks 'why' or 'how'. Examiners say many answers gave descriptions and lost marks.

"Most responses gave descriptive answers rather than explanations." Examiner report, November 2023, Paper 9626/12, p. 6

"Responses that described what each server was did not answer the question." Examiner report, November 2022, Paper 9626/31, p. 12

"there is usually little or no credit given for describing what the point or process is since this does not answer the question 'how'" Examiner report, November 2022, Paper 9626/31, p. 12

2. Leaving out the reason is the most common mistake. Short, vague phrases like 'store web sites' or 'makes the code more readable' do not get full marks.

"A common mistake was to omit a reason or expansion to the response – the question asked for explanations" Examiner report, November 2023, Paper 9626/32, p. 16

"Vague responses such as 'store web sites' were not sufficient to be awarded marks." Examiner report, November 2022, Paper 9626/31, p. 12

"a significant number only stated that comment make the code more readable so did not gain the full marks." Examiner report, March 2024, Paper 9626/32, p. 8

3. Use exact technical words. In one encryption question, about half of the answers said encrypted data 'cannot be read' when the right idea was that it cannot be understood. Those answers got no mark for it.

"Many candidates made the point that encrypted data can not be understood, but an approximately equal number stated that encrypted data could not be read, and were not awarded marks." Examiner report, June 2024, Paper 9626/11, p. 4

TIPS

1. An explanation has two parts. First you make a statement. Then you give a reason, a purpose or more detail about that statement.

"An explanation requires a statement or description followed by a reason or purpose or further expansion of that statement" Examiner report, June 2024, Paper 9626/32, p. 23

"Explanations require a statement and an expansion, which is often a reason but can be additional facts, to fully answer the question." Examiner report, November 2022, Paper 9626/31, p. 14

"An explanation is statement of fact with a reason or expansion giving its purpose." Examiner report, March 2024, Paper 9626/32, p. 8

2. Join the statement to its reason with a linking word. In the mark schemes, the expansion usually starts with 'so', 'so that', 'because', 'as' or 'which means'. Write the link word, so the examiner can see where the reason is.

"Can be adapted (automatically) in response to changing conditions/change of staff (1st) – so that new employees can have access (1)" Mark scheme 9626/32, March 2024, Q7, p. 7

"The lower the sample rate, the smaller the file size (1st) – because there is less data stored (1)" Mark scheme 9626/12, March 2024, Q10(b), p. 9

"A good answer would have stated that there is no central governing authority which means that there is no oversight or regulation" Examiner report, November 2022, Paper 9626/31, p. 14

"stating the task 'to check that the project has ended' should have been followed by a reason such as 'so that all stakeholders and clients can agree that no further additions or changes are necessary'" Examiner report, June 2025, Paper 9626/33, p. 25

3. If the question has a scenario, use it. Your reasons should fit the situation in the question, not just be general facts.

"As with all scenario-based questions, candidates are advised to consider the significance of this scenario." Examiner report, November 2023, Paper 9626/13, p. 9

"The full range of marks is only available to candidates for answers referring to the scenario in the questions." Examiner report, November 2022, Paper 9626/31, p. 12

WORKED EXAMPLE

Q3(c) [3 marks] “Mainframe computers were developed from the need for computers to process data in tasks such as carrying out a census. (c) Explain why mainframe computers are used to process the data from a census.” Question paper 9626/13, November 2023, p. 3

A full-mark answer, built from the mark scheme (not a real candidate's):

1. A census collects a very large amount of data that has to be processed,
earns: “The amount of data that has to be processed is very large (1st)” Mark scheme 9626/13, November 2023, p. 4
2. as countries tend to have a lot of people and each person adds more data.
earns: “as countries tend to have a lot of people (1)” Mark scheme 9626/13, November 2023, p. 4
3. All of this data also needs to be processed in a short period of time, so a mainframe with a high processing speed is used.
earns: “All data needs to be processed in a short period of time (1st)” Mark scheme 9626/13, November 2023, p. 4

A weak answer of the kind the examiners describe (written for this guide; likely 2 of 3):

There is a lot of data in a census. Mainframes are very reliable.

Both sentences are only first marks with no reason after them. The mark scheme says answers that are all first marks get a maximum of two, and the examiners said most answers stopped at 'a large amount of data'.

“Typically, however, responses tended to focus on that fact that there is usually a large amount of data.” Examiner report, November 2023, Paper 9626/13, p. 9

Adding 'as countries tend to have a lot of people' turns a statement into an explanation and unlocks the third mark. Think about why the scenario (a census) needs a mainframe.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Q10(a) [3 marks] “Explain how each of these methods keeps data safe from unauthorised users. (a) encryption” Question paper 9626/11, June 2024, p. 11

A full-mark answer, built from the mark scheme (not a real candidate's):

1. Encryption scrambles the data,
earns: “Data is scrambled (1st)” Mark scheme 9626/11, June 2024, p. 9
2. so that it cannot be understood by anyone who intercepts it,
earns: “so it is not understandable (1)” Mark scheme 9626/11, June 2024, p. 9
3. which means the data is of no use to a hacker or any other third party.
earns: “of no use to a hacker/third party (1)” Mark scheme 9626/11, June 2024, p. 9

A weak answer of the kind the examiners describe (written for this guide; likely 0 of 3):

Encryption makes the data unreadable so hackers cannot read it.

It does not say the data is scrambled, so the first mark is missing and the two expansion marks cannot follow. 'Cannot be read' is the wrong idea; the examiners wanted 'cannot be understood'.

“Rather than making data unreadable, encryption puts data into a state whereby it can not be understood.” Examiner report, June 2024, Paper 9626/11, p. 4

One point and two linked reasons can earn all three marks. The first statement is the gateway; each 'so' or 'which means' adds a mark.

How much evidence: Explain is common (176 parts from 2022 to 2025 in cw_parts.json), so the evidence is broad. But only 38 of those mark schemes use the explicit (1st)/(1) labels; the rest simply list points worth one mark each. The cap for answers that are 'all only first marks' is written out in 9626_w23_ms_13 Q3(c); other mark schemes show the same idea through 'Max two for one complete explanation' (9626_m24_ms_12) and the s24 ER comment, but it is not printed on every Explain question.

Where this comes from

Every statement in this guide is followed by the words it rests on, copied from a Cambridge document, with the page. There are 52 quotations from 20 documents: the 9626 syllabus for 2025–2027, the Cambridge Learner Guide for 9626, and the question papers, mark schemes and examiner reports for Papers 1 and 3 from 2017 to March 2026. A script checked each quotation word for word against the document it cites and wrote in the page number it found; the guide will not build if any quotation fails that check.

The worked examples use real questions. The full-mark answers were written for this guide by joining mark scheme points into sentences, and each sentence shows the mark scheme point it earns. The weak answers were also written for this guide, to show a mistake an examiner report describes. Neither is a real candidate's work.

What is not here: Cambridge's Example Candidate Responses booklets for 9626 (real scripts with examiner comments). They are on the School Support Hub, which needs a teacher login, so this guide does not quote them.

Limits: the share of marks per command word comes from automatic reading of the question papers. A part with no command word of its own counts under the word of the part before it. Papers 2 and 4 (practical) are not included.